Water Hickory

Carya aquatica

Family: Not stated Also known as: —

GARDENS Piedmont: 5 **TOTAL 5**



Summer / form
Library candidate

Not available

Fall color
Not available

Not available

Flower
Not available



Leaf close-up
Library candidate

QUICK FACTS & PLANTING

Type: Tree
Evergreen/Deciduous: Deciduous
Mature size: 60–100 ft (native habitat; sources range 40–60 ft to 80–100+ ft). **Open:** Cultivated height is typically smaller; no tight three-source agreement on landscape size. × 30–50 ft. Confirmed range by multiple sources.
Hardiness / Zone 8a: Suitable for Zone 8a. Hardy Zones 6–9. Native to the southeastern U.S. including Georgia. Thrives in wet bottomlands, floodplains, and periodically inundated sites. Slow growing. Restart pass (2026-10-13): Regional sources confirm wet-site preference. Existing notes stand.
Sun: Full sun to part shade.
Water: High. Prefers moist to wet soil. Tolerates seasonal flooding and poorly drained sites.
Soil: Moist to wet. Prefers rich bottomland soils. Adaptable once established.
Growth rate: Not stated
Not stated
Planting:
Siting: Plant in full sun to part shade in moist to wet, well-drained or periodically flooded soil. Best for large sites with wet conditions. Water regularly if not in naturally wet site. Slow to establish. Minimal pruning.
Soil prep: Moist to wet. Prefers rich bottomland soils. Adaptable once established.
Depth/spacing: Not stated
Season: Not stated
Establishment: Not stated

ORIGIN, CHARACTERISTICS & HEALTH

Origin / native: Native to southeastern U.S. bottomlands, swamps, and floodplains. Endemic to the region.
Form / habit: Deciduous. Large tree. Tall straight trunk with narrow to moderately spreading crown. Slow growth.
Foliage: Dull yellow.
Flowers / fruit: Not stated
Bark / stem: Light gray to brown. Exfoliating in long strips or plates (shaggy appearance).
Not stated
Health:
Health notes: No serious problems uniquely stated. Slow growth. Nuts are bitter (not for human consumption). Supports wildlife. **Open:** Specific pest/disease data for Zone 8a is thin.
Not stated
Additional:
- Pinnately compound leaves with 9–13 leaflets. - Bitter nuts (not edible by humans; eaten by wildlife). - Tolerates flooding and wet clay soils. - Slow growing. Important for wetland ecology. - Shaggy bark.